Debate Tournament Prep Plan

Nov 3, 2026 · @Nathan S.

We have one team of three students and five 55-minute classes. Most of the topics are new to them, so the plan spends most class time on **getting to know the arguments**, one or two motions at a time, rather than on full mock debates (which need six speakers). Our sides are known: **Government** on *THBT companies should become public companies when they want to grow* in Round 1 (notes allowed), and **Opposition** on the other four motions. The final motion is unknown.

How the tournament works

Each team has three speakers and debates three preliminary rounds; the top team in each league goes to the final. Only Round 1 is prepared in advance.

Round	Motion	Side	Prep	Notes allowed?
Prelim 1	Announced in advance	Fixed by draw sheet (left = Government)	At home + on the day	Yes (the only round)
Prelim 2	Random from announced list	Rock-paper-scissors winner picks	20 min	No: blank A4 memo paper only
Prelim 3	Random from announced list	Rock-paper-scissors winner picks	20 min, no feedback after	No
Final	Director's choice, may be outside the book	—	30 min	No

Speaking order: PM → LO → DPM → DLO → GW → OW. Each speech is 3 minutes, with 30 seconds of grace (anything after 3:30 is not scored). The next speaker gets 1 minute to prepare a rebuttal.

Speaker	Government	Opposition	Job
1st	Prime Minister (PM)	Leader of Opposition (LO)	PM: define the motion, give 2 main arguments (no rebuttal expected). LO: rebut the PM, give 2 main arguments

Speaker	Government	Opposition	Job
2nd	Deputy PM (DPM)	Deputy LO (DLO)	Rebut the other side, rebuild your leader's case, add 1 new argument
3rd	Government Whip (GW)	Opposition Whip (OW)	Pick the 2 main clashes and explain why your side won them. **No new arguments**

POI rules (new this year):

- Only between 1:00 and 2:30. The judge rings once at 1:00 and twice at 2:30.
- Only to 1st and 2nd speakers, never to the Whip.
- Offer by standing; keep it under 15 seconds. The clock keeps running.
- A speaker **cannot decline the first POI** offered to them. Later ones can be declined. Declining the first one costs Role points.

Scoring (per speaker, out of 100): Logic 50 + Delivery 25 + Role 25. Team total out of 300; the higher total always wins.

- **Logic** = AREL on the clash points: **A**ssertion (claim), **R**easoning (why), **E**vidence (proof/example), **L**ink (back to the clash and motion).
- **Delivery** = clear and easy to hear, confident and convincing.
- **Role** = doing your position's job, POIs (offering and answering), rebuttal, fitting the team case.

Prizes worth telling students about: Champion 100%, Finalist 50%, 3rd 30% tuition discount. The 3 highest individual scorers outside the final teams get 20% (Simson Awards), so every speech counts even if the team loses.

Watch-outs: books and templates vs. the 2026 rules

The materials were written for older or longer formats. Tell students to follow the rulebook where they disagree.

Material	What it says	2026 rule	What to tell students
Speech templates	4-minute speeches	3 minutes (+30 s grace)	Use the 3-minute timings in the handout below. Cut examples first, never the Claim or Impact

Material	What it says	2026 rule	What to tell students
Speech templates	Reply speech (2 min)	No Reply speaker; the 3rd speaker is the Whip	Skip the Reply page. Its "two worlds" idea is still useful for the Whip
Topic books, Day 4 POI page	POIs any time after the first definition; any POI can be refused	Only 1:00–2:30; first POI must be accepted; none to the Whip	Practise accepting the first POI and answering in one sentence
Topic books, ballot	67–83 points per speech, ±1–2 for POIs	Logic 50 / Delivery 25 / Role 25 = 100	Use the 2026 rubric when you give feedback on the Round 1 run-through
Topic books, Day 3	DPM/DLO model speeches mostly repeat the leader's case	Templates ask the deputy for 1 new argument	The PM/LO announces three arguments and gives two; the deputy delivers the third
Topic books, Day 3 model speeches	Full scripts to read	No notes in Rounds 2–3	Use the scripts as listening/reading models, not as something to memorise word for word

The PM's 3 minutes are tight: if they take a POI (≈20 s), they need to finish their two arguments by about 2:40. Have 1st and 2nd speakers practise at 2:45 of content.

Class plan

Each student keeps one role all course: 1st speaker (PM, or LO in Opposition rounds), 2nd speaker (DPM / DLO) or Whip (GW / OW). Each motion is studied on **our side**, with the other side read only so students know what they must answer. Every motion uses the same 15-minute routine: words (0–3) → they will say (3–7) → we say (7–12) → "Even if" (12–15).

Class 1 (Thu Nov 5) — Our team and the Round 1 motion

1. **0–10 min:** How the tournament works. Show the rounds and our sides, then the PM, DPM and GW jobs. Assign roles and record them on the team roles sheet.
2. **10–20 min:** Build an argument (Claim → Mechanism → Impact) as one group of three on the worksheet: one student per part, then swap and check.

3. **20–40 min:** Read Going Public together. Teach the 5 key words, read the Aug book's Day 1 Background aloud paragraph by paragraph, then show both sides.
4. **40–50 min:** Our case in one sentence. Each student says our side in one sentence, then one argument with sentence frames. Go round twice.
5. **50–55 min:** Set Homework 1.

Class 2 (Tue Nov 10) — Our Round 1 case: Going Public

1. **0–7 min:** Card check. Students read their Government cards aloud; compare with the answer key.
2. **7–20 min:** Split the case. PM: definition + Arguments 1–2. DPM: answer the LO + Argument 3. GW: the 2 clashes.
3. **20–32 min:** Answer Opposition. Teach "They said… / But… / Even if…". Each student answers one Opposition argument aloud.
4. **32–44 min:** POIs. Play the timeline, do 3–4 POI cards, then the teacher speaks as Opposition so students can offer POIs, and offers one POI to each student's 60-second speech.
5. **44–55 min:** Each student writes a bullet-point outline for their part; set Homework 2.

Class 3 (Thu Nov 12) — Opposition: Rent freezes and Humanoid robots

1. **0–6 min:** Round 1 warm-up: each student reads the opening of their outline aloud.
2. **6–14 min:** The answer frame again, with 2–3 thirty-second drills on Government arguments.
3. **14–30 min:** Rent freezes, using the routine.
4. **30–46 min:** Humanoid robots, using the routine.
5. **46–55 min:** One Opposition argument each in 60 seconds; set Homework 3.

Class 4 (Tue Nov 17) — Opposition: Excess profits, Equality vs. equity, and the Whip

1. **0–6 min:** Card check: draw Rent freezes or Humanoid robots; one argument and one "Even if".
2. **6–21 min:** Excess profits, using the routine.
3. **21–36 min:** Equality vs. equity, using the routine.
4. **36–50 min:** The Whip: one clash in 60 seconds with one weighing tool (Even if or Bigger). PM and DPM write POIs, then give the GW one tip.
5. **50–55 min:** Set Homework 4.

Class 5 (Thu Nov 19) — Round 1 run-through and final prep

1. **0–25 min:** Round 1 run-through with notes. Students give PM, DPM and GW; you read the LO, DLO and OW model speeches from the Aug book's Day 3 pages (shortened to about 2 minutes). One tip each at the end.
2. **25–37 min:** Opposition review: draw one of the four Opposition motions; two arguments and one "Even if" in 60 seconds.
3. **37–48 min:** Surprise final motion: plan one together (who wins, who loses, short and long term, one argument per side, who says what). No speeches.
4. **48–55 min:** Tournament-day schedule and rules.

Homework

Two short tasks per class, about 20–30 minutes in total. Students fill only **our side's** page of each topic card and read the other side.

Homework 1 (after Class 1)

- [ ] Read Going Public in Debate Topics Made Easy (English or Korean)
- [ ] Fill the Government page of the Going Public topic card

Homework 2 (after Class 2)

- [ ] Finish your Round 1 outline (bullet points only)
- [ ] Read Rent freezes and Humanoid robots in Debate Topics Made Easy

Homework 3 (after Class 3)

- [ ] Fill the Opposition page for Rent freezes and Humanoid robots
- [ ] Read Excess profits and Equality vs. equity in Debate Topics Made Easy

Homework 4 (after Class 4)

- [ ] Fill the Opposition page for Excess profits and Equality vs. equity
- [ ] Say your Round 1 speech aloud twice with your outline (aim for about 2:45)

Before tournament day

- [ ] Read your Round 1 outline and your four Opposition cards once
- [ ] Get a good night's sleep

The five motions at a glance

Each book argues its motion from two perspectives; these are the two clashes students should expect. The "type" column uses the templates' rule for choosing arguments.

Motion (book)	Type	Proposition: 2 arguments + example	Opposition: 2 arguments + example	Clash questions
THBT rent freezes are a form of harmful populism (Jan)	Mixed	1. Distorts the market: landlords stop renting or repairing, supply falls, rents jump later (Berlin 2019). 2. Unfair to newcomers: young people and newlyweds face fewer homes and higher rent (Barcelona)	1. Economic stability: renters keep money to spend locally (Barcelona). 2. Protects the vulnerable when rent rises faster than income (Vienna)	Does it help or hurt the housing market long term? Who is protected, and who is left out?
THBT humanoid robots like Atlas must be restricted from fully replacing humans in automobile factories (Mar)	Practical	1. Social stability: mass layoffs, workers can't retrain fast, towns decline (Amazon warehouses). 2. Economy needs buyers: unemployment cuts spending; big firms gain most (Foxconn, GM)	1. Safety and progress: robots take dangerous jobs; tech changes jobs rather than removing them (Tesla, Microsoft). 2. Competitiveness: productivity, lower costs, new industries (BMW retraining, Toss)	Does fast automation break society or move it forward? Is efficiency or a stable consumer base better for growth?

Motion (book)	Type	Proposition: 2 arguments + example	Opposition: 2 arguments + example	Clash questions
THBT companies' excess profits should be distributed to workers before shareholders (Jul)	Mixed	1. Fair reward for labour; reduces the gap between asset owners and wage earners (Samsung 2026 bonus deal). 2. More spending and productivity: workers spend locally; motivation and loyalty (ESOPs, efficiency wage)	1. New inequality: big-company workers gain, subcontractors and small-business workers don't; shareholders took the risk (Samsung exclusions). 2. Less investment: investors leave; bonuses hard to cut; less money for R&D (Samsung chip investment)	Who deserves the reward: labour or risk-taking capital? Does sharing grow or shrink the company long term?
THBT companies should become public companies when they want to grow (Aug)	Practical	1. More money: shares don't need repaying like loans (Amazon IPO 1997). 2. Better decisions: disclosure and boards check careless founders (Meta 2012, WhatsApp)	1. Can grow without an IPO: private investors and banks; founder keeps control (SpaceX). 2. Faster, bolder decisions without quarterly stock-price pressure (SpaceX rocket failures)	Is going public the best way to fund growth? Does market pressure improve decisions or scare off long-term risks?

Motion (book)	Type	Proposition: 2 arguments + example	Opposition: 2 arguments + example	Clash questions
THBT treating everyone the same cannot achieve true equality (Sep)	Principle	1. Same rules keep old advantages (SNU: Seoul students 2.6× admission rate, ~92% linked to family money and private education). 2. Equity protects dignity and real choice (visually impaired CSAT takers get 1.7× time, Braille)	1. Fair criteria are hard to set; people fall into blind spots (Basic Pension Act excluding low-income retired officials). 2. Reverse discrimination: judged by group, not ability (US Supreme Court 2023, Harvard/UNC)	Do equal rules hide unequal starting points? Is different treatment fair, or a new unfairness?

The Equality motion is a principle motion: remind students not to argue about money or convenience there. Atlas and Going Public are practical: two "what happens" arguments, no invented moral rights.

Student handouts

Print or copy these for students. All of them are meant to be memorised, because only the Round 1 speech can be brought in on paper.

Topic card (one per motion)

Part	Proposition	Opposition
Motion in my own words		
Key words and what they mean		
Argument 1: Claim		
Argument 1: Because… so…		
Argument 1: For example…		
Argument 1: This matters because… (who, how many, how long)		

Part	Proposition	Opposition
Argument 2: Claim		
Argument 2: Because… so…		
Argument 2: For example…		
Argument 2: This matters because…		
Third argument for the deputy (a new group of people or a long-term effect)		
"Even if…" answer to the other side's best point		
2 POI questions to ask the other side		
Clash 1 question		
Clash 2 question		

3-minute speech timings

These cut the 4-minute templates to fit the 3-minute rule. Use the same template pages; only the times change.

Speaker	Section times (total 3:00)
PM	Motion, definition, model 0:25 → The problem 0:15 → Signposting 0:10 → Argument 1 0:55 → Argument 2 0:55 → Call to action 0:20
LO	Clash of visions 0:30 → Rebuttal of the PM 0:35 → Signposting 0:10 → Argument 1 0:45 → Argument 2 0:40 → Structural promise 0:20
DPM / DLO	Framing 0:20 → Rebuttal 0:50 → Rebuilding the leader's case 0:35 → New argument 0:55 → Summary 0:20
GW / OW	Rebut the last speaker 0:30 → Clash 1 0:55 → Clash 2 0:55 → Final weighing 0:20 → Final ballot 0:20

PMs, LOs and deputies will lose about 20 seconds to the POI they must accept, so they should aim for 2:45 of content.

Using the 20 minutes of prep time

1. **0–3 min (together):** Read the motion. Define the key words. Practical, principle or mixed?
2. **3–8 min (together):** List who is affected. Brainstorm the 2 strongest arguments for **both** sides, using what you remember from the book.
3. **8–15 min (alone):** 1st speaker writes 2 arguments; 2nd speaker writes the third argument plus answers to the other side's likely points; Whip writes the 2 clash questions.
4. **15–20 min (together):** Predict the other team's top 2 arguments and agree on one "Even if" answer for each. Plan 2 POIs per person.

Unseen motions for the final-style drill

The final may use a motion outside the books. Practise the 20-minute plan on motions like these:

- THBT schools should ban smartphones during the school day.
- THBT AI tutors will do more good than harm for students.
- THBT cities should make public transport free.
- THBT companies should be allowed to choose a four-day work week.

For any unseen motion, ask: who wins, who loses, what changes in the short term, what changes in the long term?